

Interview with Elaine Bibuld

February 18, 2001

**Edited version of interview on file at the Brooklyn Public Library, Central Branch,
Brooklyn Collection**

Brian Purnell (BP): Today is February 18th. I am meeting with Mrs. Bibuld. Could you spell your name real quick?

Elaine Bibuld (EB): B-i-b-u-l-d. First name Elaine.

BP: Could you speak a little bit about how you got involved in Brooklyn CORE? What attracted you to the group?

EB: OK, I was - - I was bored. Its true and I was seeking something and I didn't know what. And my husband at that time had read about Brooklyn CORE and he said, why don't you get involved with this? And I don't remember how exactly I happened to find them or go to them, but anyway, I did get involved. Oh yes, I do remember. They mentioned Oliver Leeds. Oliver Leeds had introduced me to my husband seven years before. That's how we met.

BP: Who was Oliver Leeds? I know he was the chairman of Brooklyn CORE for some time.

EB: Yeah he was in printing as far as I know. He was a printer or something like that. He was very well educated but he didn't talk much about it, about his background. But he had things together, he pulled things together, he was able to point us in the direction that we needed to go and we were glad to follow him.

BP: How did you meet him?

EB: I was working on, I was a teenager, I think about 17 years old and I had left home that year and I was sharing an apartment with three other girls. And there was this Ben Davis

campaign. Ben Davis was running for Councilman. I got involved that way and for the first time in my life at that time I saw slums because I hadn't seen one before.

BP: Not to interrupt, but where are you from?

EB: The Northeast part of the Bronx, a part called Williamsbridge. It was all farms and very rural up there.

BP: What year were you born?

EB: 1930. So I hadn't seen any of this other side. It was upper-middle-class. I hadn't seen the slums or anything like that. I had not concept of it. I remember I was so impressed I went into a house canvassing. I stepped through the door and there was no glass in the door. So I stepped through it and as I looked up I could see the sky. And I went into this woman's apartment and it was so clean and it was neat and it was such a contrast to me. It was just amazing to me at the time. And that campaign was where I met Ollie. I think that was it. I'm not sure now because you know, come to think of it - - Yeah somewhere yeah, that's right. And then I didn't see him after that. I didn't see him for a long while but then when my husband brought up this CORE business and mentioned Ollie's name, and that's when I got involved.

BP: What did that mean to CORE, to be racially integrated?

EB: Not very much. It wasn't - - it didn't really matter to me. It was just a matter of somebody thinking the same way that you do, willing to do what you're willing to do. It was a very strong camaraderie. And it had very little, if anything to do with white or black. It really didn't, at least as far as I'm concerned. Now others may have had another view, but then I had an interracial marriage too.

BP: Could speak a little bit about how that dynamic, how people reacted to that dynamic, or how that influenced - -

EB: Well you know for the first years of our marriage we were so busy fighting outside forces that were against it or thought it was horrible or something that we didn't really - - that's what kept us together because we were very different people, had very divergent ideas, later on, that we learned, because I finally divorced him, but we had children together. It was an inimical divorce.

But I remember one time we were sitting on the train and somebody opposite us was reading the paper, a white person, because we were sitting arm-in-arm, he pulled down the paper like this and he actually leaned across the aisle in the train this is and my husband leaned across and their noses were about that far apart. And my husband says to him, what are you looking at? And the guy said, uh - - nothing. And we laughed and we had the whole car laughing. There's a lot of funny things like that.

BP: What year were you married?

EB: 1948. My parents didn't think it was good idea. And his stepmother didn't think it was a good idea. And we were married for 27 years.

BP: Maybe we can talk a little about the school campaign that you were the focus of, from what I'm getting in the press. Maybe if you can speak a little about some things that might not be in here. What happened initially? From what I've seen in some newspaper clippings, you had two children at that time - -

EB: Three

BP: Three that were going to school?

EB: Yes. Douglass was 10, Carr was 8, and Melanie was 6. And we were living on Union Street and they were going to school about a block away. And it was an integrated, well it wasn't exactly integrated but it was just becoming integrated and my kids were in the accelerated

classes. And we had a fire. And we had to find a place fast to live. And we left that area and moved down here to 4th street. And the schools in this area, or at least in that area of 4th street, were terrible. I mean it was as bad as I guess they are still today.

Douglass came home one day and showed me - - I thought they were missing their old school. I didn't recognize the dissatisfaction they had at the time for what it was and actually, Douglass came and showed me a paper and he threw it at me. And it said 100 on it, a spelling paper. And I said, Oh that's great! Usually he made good marks. But he said, Look at it Mommy! Look at it! And I looked at it and I realized that these were the words that you learned in first of second grade. And here was a kid that was studying introductory algebra, learning about poetic imagery, because I had been with his class to read Emma Lazarus's poem at the bottom of the Statue of Liberty and things like that. These were the kinds of things they were learning. And to go to a school where the fifth grade class was working at least a third grade level. That was, you know...

When I recognized what was happening, I went to the school and I asked them if they couldn't do something, if this was the best they had if they couldn't skip him or something because he wasn't learning. And they said they couldn't do anything. I went to the Board of Education. They couldn't do anything. District Superintendent: he couldn't do anything. So because I couldn't get their attention I went to CORE and up to this time I had been very content to sit back and have my own opinion but not need to say anything, you know, and this time I was really riled up. And I *slammed* my hands down on the stand and said, I WANT SOME HELP! I WANT YOU TO HEAR ME! And made them listen to what my problem was. And then Ollie said, OK you need a committee to work with. So you need some hands. And a committee was formed with Arnie Goldwag, and I forgot who else was in it, but we did most of the work. They were on the picket lines and came to the sit-ins but the initial work was Arnie and I.

We went to the Board of Education and got their own maps and proved that this area was segregated. That this area around the circle there was separate from just a few blocks away from where lived on 4th street and they couldn't or wouldn't allow the children to cross the lines that they had drawn. And when we got these maps and we saw where the good school were and the poor schools were it was so obvious that it was purely segregation. And so we used that. I don't know if there's any maps in here, but we used their maps to prove it. And then still nothing happened. And the Board of Education took no notice of us. I took them out of school and sat them in – a friend of mine's children were going to school in Bensonhurst. And we sat them in there. And we had to have police come here to take us from the house on 4th street and I don't know I think it was 4th Ave. and we had to have police walk us because they had Klu Klux Klan and White Citizens Councils and all these crazy groups were close enough to us to drop stuff in the mailbox, unstamped – stuff in the mailbox – the Nazi Party and all this - - And so we eventually got a dog, a big one, a big red ugly dog and my husband got a shotgun.

I think I had mentioned about them calling us up on the phone one night at the wee hours of the morning. I get this call and this guy says he was so-and-so of the Grand Council of the Klu Klux Klan, and I just thought it was some local nut. But, I hung up the phone and a couple minutes later the call comes through so I should know where it came from. He had routed it through the operator. And that's how I knew it was authentic and it had come from the South. The next day I call Arnie and I said, you know, guess who called me? This guy, the Grand Pubah from the Klu Klux Klan and I mentioned his name and Arnie said, that was real! At first I really didn't - - because people were upset that I wanted my kids to go to a decent school. The craziest people were upset about it. So I hadn't really given it much thought. I had just mentioned it passing that this person routed the call through Virginia so that I would know where it came

from and I was telling Arnie and Arnie said, Gasp! Then he put the whole thing in the newspaper. And from then on the thing kept escalating.

BP: Did they eventually go to the other school?

EB: Well what happened was, we had police take us because we were threatened and we had all this put into the paper. Arnie was good at getting publications about what was happening.

And so then the police walked us from our house to the subway station. We got on there. And the Transit Police guarded on the train to the other end. And then the police from that end took us to the school, all walking mind you. And this happened day after day, as long as the kids were in that school.

BP: In the one that they previously attended?

EB: No, in the one where we sat them in.

BP: In Bensonhurst.

EB: Yes. So, then eventually, by the way Douglass was received very happily. Carr was kind of so-so, and I don't really remember what Melanie's day was like. She was just six and anything was good for her. She didn't have any bad experiences. But, Carr did, my second son did. He didn't have a good time at all.

But Douglass was accepted in the class. By the way, Douglass had one book had the cover off it – it was a Math book – had neither the front nor back cover on it, a Math book and one other book, I can't remember what it was. But that's all they had. And in that other school we sat them in they had about twelve books apiece. And when Douglass walked in the class, they began the class day with an overture on recorders. Fortunately, Douglass had music lessons and on the recorder, before we even thought of doing this, just as a thing for the summer.

BP: Your middle son had a bit of a tougher time?

EB: Yeah, and I don't know too much about it because Carr didn't talk about it and he has never been an activist, but he's extremely intelligent about the time and stuff, but he just was not an activist. Douglass was kind of forced to be because he wanted what he had had before in school. So, that's why I talk mostly about him because he was the one that I first sat-in and told him, don't move unless somebody from CORE moves you and he stayed and they couldn't get him out of the classroom. And they let him stay that day, and then the next day and the next day, and his teacher fell in love with him. *Loved* him, because one of the things she told me about him was that Douglass would not permit the class to go on if he did not understand something. That he would *stop* them. To think that a ten-year-old kid would have that kind of gumption, is something. I'm very proud of him. And, his teacher told me about that. She cried when he left. She said he was a student she was very proud to have had in the class.

And the Board of Education, we were still having meetings with them and getting no place. And they wanted to talk to me – wanted to talk *down* to me and tell me what I should do and what I couldn't do. By that time I was *livid* at any rate because I didn't want my kid at seventeen or eighteen years old standing out here on the corner some place, having dropped out of school and all that business. I didn't want that for my children. And it didn't happen.

BP: Could you speak a little bit about the “Free Elaine Bibuld” campaign that went on after the protest at the Downstate Medical Center, where Brooklyn CORE protested to get more jobs for Black construction workers?

EB: I think my husband and I were sort of picked out as leaders, though we *weren't*; not particular leaders, just a vocal part of the group. And we were going around, marching around and we think that they had picked us out because cops started to mess around with Doug, pushing Doug.

BP: Your son?

EB: Yeah. And he was walking in front of my husband. And my husband naturally got very upset. “*What are you doing?*” and battered the cop’s hand off Douglass. And the next thing you know they were wrestling my husband to the ground. And I was on the opposite side of this huge circle and I saw this going and I went clear across the circle and just as I got this policeman, one had his knee in my husband’s groin and the other had torn the zipper and it was rubbing – and my husband still has the scar on his neck – rubbing the broken zipper on my husband’s neck. But the cop that was kneeling in his lap, by the time I got to him he was just swinging under the horse (the barricade) and as he swung away, the kick that I had meant to go where you shouldn’t kick a man – I meant to get him right through his head – if I had connected he would have been crippled to this day! – but it caught him in the middle of the back. And it was a *hard* kick too!

BP: I have a quick question about that. CORE is founded on principles of - -

EB: Non-violence! That’s all right (Laughter) sometimes we, I personally had not up until that point been ready to attack anybody, but that was my husband and my child! And I was ready to hurt them.

BP: Was there ever any discussions during CORE group meetings - -

EB: About non-violence?

BP: About non-violence, about possibly defending oneself or engaging in physical activity with other people?

EB: Well, I do remember talks about being non-violent, but I don’t remember how we were supposed to go about protecting ourselves. I don’t think there was any talk about that. Actually, there really wasn’t a hell of a lot you could do about it. But where we marched most of the times you didn’t have any problems like that. We weren’t attacked by police or anything like they were

in the South. We did have people talk and sometimes they through eggs or something. But nothing serious. So we weren't really challenged that way.

But this business at the Downstate thing – the police were mean. That was the good thing – whenever there was an action, Arnie always notified the papers so that there were photographers around. So that even though we were thrown in the paddy wagon we weren't hurt on the way in. But when the cameras weren't on us, cops would put their heels on our hands and squish them like that, do things like that to us. Or hit us! I never got hit, but I did have my hand stepped on like that, purposely, when they were boosting me into the paddy wagon. I put my hand on the thing like this... most of the time we were protected because there was publicity.

BP: So you got arrested and Judge Phipps - -

EB: Well, what happened was I kicked this cop, as I said. I didn't kick him where I intended to, therefore I didn't do nothing. I didn't do *anything* to this man. Because if I had done it, he would have been crippled, and I *meant* it too. So they put my husband and I in handcuffs, and handcuffed us behind our back. And I have this thing: I hate to be tied – Oh! Its terrible. But I suffered it and we were taken to the police station and we sat there for about an hour or so. And they took us to jail. They put us in a cell and then waited for a paddy wagon and I really don't remember this too clearly.

BP: There's records that I can review and review more. I really just wanted to talk a bit about the idea of non-violence and how it fit into this one incident.

EB: We went to court and we had a court date and had to go to court and that's when Judge Phipps was on the bench and he was telling us how we should go about this, instead of marching and stuff like this. And the fact of the matter was we had done everything he said we should have done. We wrote to our Congressman and *all* the stuff you do if you want to get attention about

something. And he's going through all this. And I got so angry. I just got filled up to here. And I shook my finger at him and said, "You know what you are? You're Uncle Tom with Jim Crow sitting on your shoulder." And he said, Bam! "Ten days" and I didn't know at the time but the fix was already in and he was supposed to dismiss the case. But I mad him mad too so that's how I went to jail.

When I got in there, there was this big huge woman (break) who was the doctor. First we had to take our clothes off and go through a shower, and *ill*, all that indignity. Then we had to go into this room with this German woman – I'd swear she came out of the camps – thick accent. And she was examining, prostitutes, *everybody*, females, without changing her gloves! And I was pregnant at the time and I refused to let her touch me. No way were they going to invade me or touch me in any kind of way.

One of the policewomen said, "Oh you think we're going to beat you up or something so that you'll have scars to show? We've got something better for you." They took me and put me into solitary confinement. And the walls started coming in and coming down. I kept telling myself, this is my imagination. This is my imagination. I need sleep. And I went to sleep like *that* (snap) and didn't wake up until the next morning. Psyched myself to sleep.

The next morning the cell gate clanks open and there was a woman looking at me and I was looking at her and she says, "What are you doing?" and I says, "What are *you* doing?" and she had been on a picket line. And she was the captain of the jail. Between her and the doctor I worked for, who was a prominent woman at the time, arranged for me to be on the hospital floor, where I had a small room, that was my own, a private room.

It was an amazing experience though. While I was there, I heard, far away, I could have sworn I heard my name. And I said, of course not. Then I heard it again, and I couldn't believe it.

And I said, where is that coming from. I thought I was going ga-ga, or something. Then one of the inmates told me that there was a demonstration outside. And I went to the window and I could hear it. The windows never opened but so much, so you couldn't really see much except that across the street was a fruit stand, and that was about all I could see. I couldn't see the bodies of the people above that, just their feet. And I heard my name: "Free Elaine Bibuld. Jail Jim Crow." I was shocked. I was surprised. And they were there the whole ten days I was there. And they were... some of them were so high... the day I came out I noticed that some were so high they were kind of bending down. You know how addicts do, I guess when they have had a fix? There were guys, who you could the liquor from there to here, but nonetheless, they were on that line, marching around, and that line went twenty-four hours a day for ten days. Every time I think of it I'm amazed, shocked. I couldn't believe it.

And the inmates began to know who I was. That was another thing: I met some of the nicest people. I had a pack of cigarettes, and you heard how a pack of cigarettes are precious in jail. I used to smoke Paul Mall and I left them on the table, a whole pack, because I didn't have anything to do so I would go wash dishes because the luncheon room was on that floor. I left them on the table and a girl came and asked me if she could have a cigarette. I had forgotten I had left them there and I said, "Sure help yourself." And she was the one that told me that cigarettes were the equivalent of money. I went back to get my cigarettes and there wasn't one taken out of that pack.

BP: What jail were you in?

EB: The Women's House of Detention. It no longer exists. They tore it down. I had lost that baby I was carrying at that time. But that was amazing. I think of it now and it's still amazing.